CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

RADIOLOGY TECH IN THE AI ERA

You take the pictures that decide what happens to the patient next.

★ **TL;DR — Around $75K median after a 1–2 year accredited program and the registry credential. The catch: competitive program seats and a body that pays for bad positioning habits.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

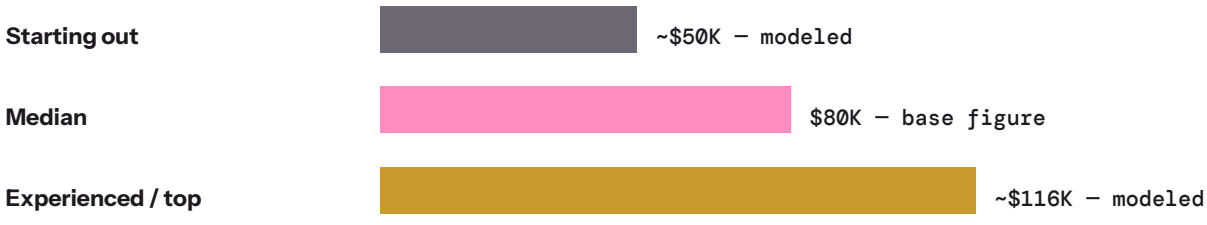
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$80K · TRAINING 1-2 years · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- Imaging is the diagnostic crossroads of the hospital — every service orders through you.
- The credential is the moat: an accredited program plus the registry exam is what separates techs from button-pushers.
- AI reads images and flags findings, but it doesn't position a trauma patient at 2 a.m. — acquisition stays human.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Radiology Tech is a ~$80K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A RADIOLOGY TECH ACTUALLY DO?

✓ Position patients and set exposures for X-rays ordered by providers

- ✓ Run portable imaging at bedsides, in the ER and in surgery
- ✓ Manage radiation safety for the patient, the room and yourself
- ✓ Check image quality and send clean studies to the radiologist

Think: a photographer whose studio is an emergency — and whose pictures are evidence.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI triages scans, flags likely findings and automates dose and protocol settings. Reconstruction software keeps getting better at fixing mediocre acquisition — within limits.	Getting a diagnostic image out of a patient in pain, post-surgery or panicking. Positioning judgment, patient handling and radiation discipline are licensed human work.

⚠ **Programs are seat-limited and science-gated; treating applications casually means waiting a year. And the lead apron years add up — lift and position smart from day one.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ A skilled trade inside medicine, with hospital-wide variety ✓ Clear advancement: CT, MRI, mammography, interventional ✓ Work is done when the shift ends — no charting mountain at home	✗ On-call nights and weekends, especially early career ✗ Heavy patients, radiation discipline, trauma cases ✗ Program admission is a real competition

Good fit? Precise, technical, calm with people in pain, and strong enough in science to win a program seat.
Bad fit? You want a quick course — this is a 1–2 year accredited pipeline with a registry exam.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — THE ACCREDITED RADIOGRAPHY PROGRAM	DOOR B — HOSPITAL-BASED PROGRAMS
Apply to an accredited radiography program (usually an associate degree, 1–2 years) with hospital clinical rotations. Graduation makes you eligible for the ARRT registry credential — the hiring standard.	Some hospital systems run their own accredited schools of radiography, often cheaper and deeply clinical. Same credential at the end; seats are few and local — apply early and broadly.

Smart move: Apply to every accredited program within reach and treat science prerequisites as the admission exam — programs rank on them, not on enthusiasm.

Where you land after: Radiographer → CT/MRI/mammo cross-training, interventional suites, imaging lead or educator.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
MAP ACCREDITED	WIN THE	APPLY WIDE	DO THE	PASS THE	TAKE THE

STEP 1 — Map accredited programs

FREE · TODAY

- List accredited radiography programs and their prerequisite lists.
- Note application windows — many admit once a year.

STEP 2 — Win the prerequisites

SEMESTER · BEFORE APPLYING

- Anatomy & physiology, math, medical terminology — grades here decide admission.
- Shadow a department for a day to confirm you like the work.

STEP 3 — Apply wide

APPLICATION SEASON

- Submit to every program you could actually attend.
- Prepare for interviews: they screen for composure and patient sense.

STEP 4 — Do the program

1–2 YEARS

- Positioning, radiation physics and safety, patient care — plus long clinical rotations.
- Collect competencies steadily; clinical sites are future employers.

STEP 5 — Pass the registry

EXAM FEE · AFTER GRADUATION

- Sit the ARRT radiography exam as soon as eligible.
- Complete any state licensing step your state requires for techs.

STEP 6 — Take the first tech job

JOB HUNT · 2–6 WEEKS

- Hospitals hire new grads from their clinical sites first.
- First year: master portable and ER work — that's where reputations form.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: list accredited programs, prerequisites and application deadlines.

□ Days 1–30: enroll in missing prerequisites; book a shadowing day in an imaging department.

□ Days 31–60: prerequisites underway with A-aiming grades; draft applications.

□ Days 61–90: submit applications to every reachable program; interview prep done.

□ Day 90: you're in the admissions pipeline — the credential is 1–2 years out, and seats are the whole game.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **PICTURES THAT DECIDE TREATMENT.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.